

Human Values & Ethics

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Values- An individual's set of principles and ideals that create their accepted/desired standards of behavior. Our *value systems* help us make decisions and priority-based judgments. What you prioritize is what your values are. We derive our values from the environment of our society that we observe.

Morality- Based on their value system, *individuals* create a belief system that helps them make a judgment about what kind of a decision is good or bad. Deferring to authority may be bravery for some (like revolution), but may be a violent act for others (like terrorism). Also see examples of Ravan, Nathuram Godse etc. Since morals are our own, they often have a gray zone.

Ethics- They are guiding principles of every community or *institution* that create a structure or code of conduct. Unlike morals, ethics are more community-based and have a clear demarcation between right/wrong and white/black. They follow uniformity for all members, are more specific and legal.

Work ethics- The code of conduct interwoven between the institution (or industry) and society is known as our work ethic. Labor work, utilization of resources and controlled investments are examples of work ethics that governs motivational orientations at

workplaces. Work ethic is concerned with economy, productivity, safety, privacy, health & hygiene, welfare, security and CSR.

Integrity- Based upon our value system and an ethical and moral understanding of the society, the unity of our thought, word and action makes us a person who has integrity.

(contd. later with Spirituality)

Moral & Ethical Challenges at a Workplace:

(explain these better with examples of your own)

1. Receiving a counter offer from other companies (leverage example)
 2. When a credit monger steals our hard-worked projects
 3. Unwilling obligation to a crime/felony (remember the bounty example)
 4. Misuse of company resources- stationery, time, etc.
 5. Becoming an unwilling witness to abuse (remember the harassment example)
 6. Leaking information (in exchange of personal benefits)
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Spirituality:

An individual's belief in a supernatural element or energy that is greater than them, that guides the world and its happenings, is known as Spirituality. When our mind and body are at the center of everything that we have to do, it makes us spiritual beings.

There is a huge difference between spirituality and religion- while religion largely means worshipping an idol, spirituality is mainly philosophical- where the individual manifests (as opposed to praying) to an unimagined entity.

Spirituality enables us to enhance our creativity (because it enables us to see things differently and uniquely), respect and sensitivity, communication, tolerance, responsibility and vision.

Spirituality at the Workplace:

Because suppressing creativity leads to destructive intents of employees, it is important for both the superior and subordinate employees to practice spirituality to become efficient resources/assets to the company. Various way of spiritual development can be doing activities like meditating, journaling, taking walks and practicing yoga. Practicing these will make us better humans and more ethical professionals. Practicing spirituality at the workplace can give:

- More energy, flexibility and diversity (inclusivity) among members
- Better ability to think and act (both ethically and morally)
- Increased sense of accountability/answerability

And as a leader, it is important to lead your employees to be spiritually inclined through the following ways:

- Understanding them as not only resources but also humans, learning about their goals
- Also respecting them VERBALLY
- Stating your ethics with them to align them in a unified goal
- CSR, it helps in an integrated value system of the organization

Service Learning:

Service learning refers to voluntary services that individuals of the society or employees of an organization provide to the society while also learning. It involves learning new policies, norms and procedures of service, instead of only learning technical trade practices. In order to become more enriched human beings and more resourceful employees, volunteering for a service while learning is an essential part of every work ethic. It also helps us in ethical interaction with our colleagues, and in developing our engagement with the society.

One can volunteer for many services like helping in old-age homes, providing service meals, experiential education, and addressing basic human and community needs.

The learning outcomes of such service learning are increased awareness of the world around us, the ability to take new initiatives (since we will overcome the problem of intolerance and learn patience), develop intellectually and spiritually, and increase our commitment and collaboration abilities.

Variety of Moral Issues:

In order to better understand the ethics of engineering and to learn why certain engineers commit immoral actions, it is necessary to see why people do such things. There are 3 types of moral issues that can be categorized for engineers to see what leads to their unethical actions:

1. **Resource Crunch-** Manipulation of available resources and compromising the quality of the project because of shortage of resources

2. **Opportunity-** Employees commit unethical actions when they:
- a. Put their interest over the company's interest
 - b. Focus on short term goals over long term goals
 - c. Work in an environment where there is no empowerment or CSR to ethically enhance themselves
3. **Working Attitude-** Employees working under extreme conditions and pressure tend to give up courtesy and sincerity towards the company's progress. Besides, lack of transparency, zero recognition for hard work, no grievance redressal system can also discourage employees' attitude.
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Moral Dilemma:

The confusion an individual faces between two solutions or decisions, that could impact their morality, is known as a moral dilemma. It complicates our decision making power because reason/rationality comes into conflict. Usually the moral dilemma is between safeguarding either out of truth and loyalty, individual and community, short term and long term goals, and justice and virtue.

While a moral dilemma is often caused because of our rights, responsibilities and duties, it can also be resolved by creating an organized and well defined system of priorities.

Situations leading to moral dilemmas: (include examples as per your novelty)

- (i) *Vagueness:* Inability to differentiate between good and bad, or right and wrong
- (ii) *Conflicting reasons:* Inability to choose between two viable and equally good solutions

(iii) *Disagreement*: Working in an organization's team or community can lead to disagreements between members over varying moral solutions

Moral Autonomy:

Moral autonomy is a *social experimentation* which is defined as, 'decisions and actions exercised on the basis of moral concern for other people and recognition of good moral reasons.' When we use our freedom of choice to be fair with others, we practice moral autonomy.

People hold moral beliefs and attitudes based on their 'critical reflection' rather than on the age-old conventions of the society or their profession. Moral autonomy may also be defined as the practice of thinking consciously and rationally about issues that no code of ethics follows but is still of moral concern to them.

(Remember examples of: coffee beans, organic foods, paper straws, labor laws/ blind CVs etc.)

Skills needed to practice moral autonomy (for individual/community):

1. The ability to first spot the problem with traditional immoral methods
 2. Ability to suggest viable solutions and make changes based on facts rather than emotion or preferences (remember examples of veganism and non-vegetarianism)
 3. The ability to make moral judgments (based on facts) that may cause trouble in our lifestyle or in the lives of others
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PLEASE NOTE:

For references on **The Challenger**, watch documentaries and interviews of Allan McDonald (available on Youtube) and formulate your understanding of engineering ethics.